Perhaps the most revealing source of all is the *Waqi'at-i-Shah Shuja*, Shah Shuja's own colourful and sympathetic memoirs, written in exile in Ludhiana before the war and brought up to date by one of his followers after his assassination in 1842. Shuja explains in his introduction that 'to insightful scholars it is well known that great kings have always recorded the events of their reigns and the victorious military campaigns in which they took part: some writing themselves, with their natural gifts, but most entrusting the writing to skilled historians, so that these pearl-like compositions would remain as a memorial on the pages of passing time. Thus it occurred to this humble petitioner at the court of the Merciful God to record the battles of his reign from the time of his accession at the young age of seventeen, so that the historians of Khurasan should know the true account of these events, and thoughtful readers take heed from these examples.'[12] In these memoirs we have the hopes and fears of the principal player on the Afghan side – a vital addition to the literature.

Yet astonishingly, while most of these sources are well known to Dari-speaking Afghan historians, and were used by them in the nationalist Dari-language histories they wrote between the 1950s and 1970s, not one of these accounts ever seems to have been used in any English-language history of the war, and none is available in English translation, although an abridged translation of a few chapters of the *Waqi'at-i-Shah Shuja* appeared in a Calcutta magazine in the 1840s and a full translation of the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh* is currently under preparation by Robert McChesney at Columbia University, to which I was generously given access.

These rich and detailed Afghan sources tell us much that the European sources neglect to mention or are ignorant of. The British sources, for example, are well informed when talking of the different factions in their own army, but seem largely unaware of the tensions dividing the different groups of insurgents who made up the Afghan side. For the Afghan resistance – it is clear in the Afghan accounts – was in fact deeply fractured: different groups under different commanders camped in different places and often acted with only the bare minimum of co-ordination. Moreover, the rival groups had different aims and formed ever-changing coalitions of self-interest. One particular surprise is how many of the insurgents at the beginning wished to retain Shah Shuja as their king and only wished to drive out his British backers; the loyalties of these same pro-Royalist forces reverted to Shah Shuja as soon as the British army headed off towards its